The Congress enters the April assembly elections across four states and one Union territory as a party fighting on radically different terms in each battleground. In Kerala, it's a dominant coalition leader. In Tamil Nadu, it's an embattled junior partner. In Assam, it struggles as a beleaguered Opposition. In West Bengal, it is barely visible, and in Puducherry, it is caught in an alliance deadlock.

This asymmetry captures the paradox of India's Grand Old Party. It's nationally relevant but regionally fragmented, capable of flashes of brilliance yet structurally weakened by decades of organisational decay, defections, the rise of muscular regional competitors and the BJP's polarising machinery.

The Congress's electoral strategy is, by necessity, patchwork: consolidate anti-incumbency where it exists, lean on regional fronts where it must and paper over internal fissures with high-command oversight. But its revival remains uneven and perilously fragile.

KERALA

Of all the states headed to polls, Kerala offers the Congress the most credible opportunity for government formation. The Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) enters the race buoyed by three consecutive electoral triumphs in the past five years: victory in four of five assembly bypolls since 2021, a sweep of 18 of 20 Lok Sabha seats in 2024 and control of 505 of 941 gram panchayats in the December 2025 local body elections.

However, Kerala's three-cornered contest means anti-incumbency doesn't flow cleanly to the Opposition. The BJP, which won its first-ever Kerala Lok Sabha seat in Thrissur in 2024 and targets 10-15 assembly seats in the 140-member House, is siphoning enough anti-Left Democratic Front (LDF) votes to potentially keep chief minister Pinarayi Vijayan in power despite a hostile electorate, claim several political observers.

Besides, the Congress's internal dynamics in Kerala remain its Achilles' heel. The party has not declared its CM candidate, though V.D. Satheesan, the leader of the Opposition, has emerged as the UDF's de facto campaign face, leading the 25-day 'Puthuyuga Yatra' that covered 121 public meetings before culminating in an address by senior leader Rahul Gandhi in Thiruvananthapuram on March 7. There are two other serious contenders—AICC general secretary in-charge of organisation, K.C. Venugopal, and Ramesh Chennithala. Another episode laid the party's tensions bare. Former KPCC president K. Sudhakaran demanded to contest the Kannur assembly seat, despite a high command edict barring sitting MPs from state elections. After days of public brinkmanship, Sudhakaran relented only on March 19, but not before the crisis delayed the Congress's second candidate list and exposed the factional fault lines between the Venugopal-Satheesan axis and the Chennithala-Sudhakaran alignment.

The campaign itself is sharply focused on anti-incumbency against the LDF's decade-long rule (2016-2026), spotlighting the Sabarimala gold theft allegations, Kerala's fiscal crisis, welfare pension delays and the controversy over the proposed K-Rail corridor, opposed for land acquisition, ecological risks and its heavy cost. Rahul, the former MP from Wayanad, has been deployed extensively, framing the election as a vote for 'change'. The appointment of election strategist Sunil Kanugolu, who was the architect of the Congress



ISLANDS OF HOPE

The Congress's ambitions in five battleground states range from a bid for outright victory to staving off another complete wipeout

↘ Kerala: The Congress leads the formidable UDF alliance, buoyed by ex-local MP Rahul Gandhi's popularity and strategist Sunil Kanugolu's tactical hand. But a tussle over CM aspirations and a multi-cornered contest cloud the picture

↘ Assam: It has assembled a six-party coalition with Gaurav Gogoi as the Opposition's CM face. Yet defections, infighting, weak ground organisation and the reduced electoral weight of the Muslim vote bank after delimitation hobble the campaign

↘ Tamil Nadu: As a junior partner to the ruling DMK, the Congress's fortunes are tied to anti-incumbency, and the impact of Vijay's TVK. Internal discontent over the alliance persists

↘ West Bengal: A battle for bare survival—no credible face, a decaying organisation and a tally of zero seats from the past election to improve upon

↘ Puducherry: The Congress had to negotiate hard with its resurgent ally, the DMK, which outperformed it in the last polls. The delay in finalising seat-sharing may have handed the NDA a decisive edge